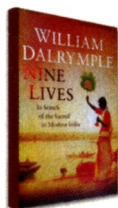


# Divine EXOTICA

Dalrymple can't resist the sensational as he sets out for the sacred in mystic India



**NINE LIVES:**  
IN SEARCH OF  
THE SACRED IN  
MODERN INDIA  
by WILLIAM DALRYMPLE  
Bloomsbury  
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| By Gillian Wright |

One thing is sure, you don't have to go far to find the sacred. All living things, the universe, your true self—all are sacred to those who have an eye to see it. At the same time, there are many far flung sacred places in India we may not have visited and very many remarkable people, with their own perception of Truth, whom we would benefit from meeting. William Dalrymple has chosen nine such individuals to illustrate his own search and, on the face of it, this should be another fine book.

However, it seems that Dalrymple is often in search not so much of the sacred as the sensational in South Asian religion. Not that he doesn't write beautifully or that he fails to pay due respect to the scholars who have gone before him. He is also careful not to intrude unnecessarily into his stories, and allows his interviewees to speak for themselves. The most moving sections of the book are undoubtedly these interviews, conducted in various Indian languages and translated into colloquial English. Proponents of Akhand Bharat will be happy to note that for Dalrymple, the boundaries of India include the Pakistani province of Sindh, but it has to be said that he has tried to maintain a regional, religious, gender and caste balance.

Still, no matter how much he moderates himself, his natural exuberance overcomes him and he cannot disguise his taste for the gruesome, or for exaggerating colourful, exotic, religious India. He begins sober explanations of all this exotica, only after he has played it up for all it's worth. Thus we have the gospel according to Dalrymple—Tantric goddesses preferring to have sex with corpses than living men, the central Tantric rite of

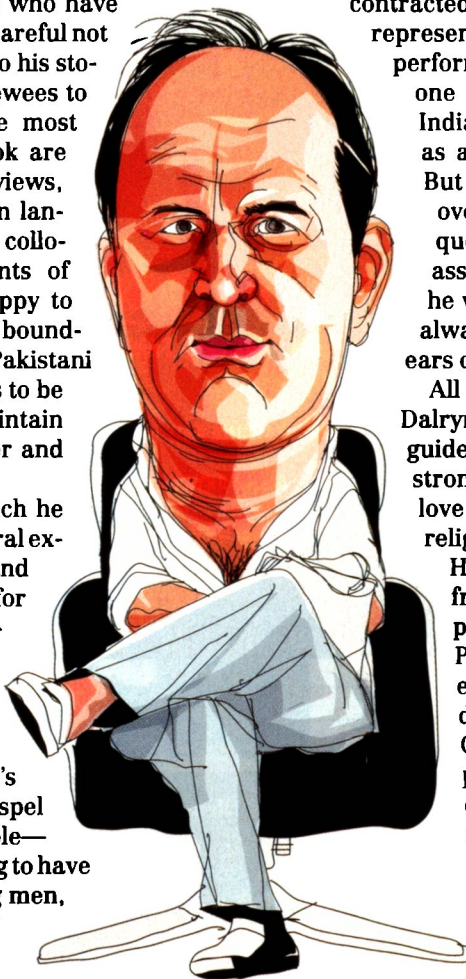
eating semen, and the common Kerala practice, until recently, of upper castes beheading Dalits for not offering them sweets. Dalrymple's hammering of the word "idol" to describe Chola bronzes at times makes him sound like an old-fashioned Roman Catholic among the heathen, while specialists in other subjects he has written about told me they found his treatment superficial and distorting.

The nine people he features live, for the most part, on the margins of society, and they have had extremely hard, tragic lives. From Karnataka, Dalrymple chooses an HIV-infected "devdasi" dedicated to Yellamma, both of whose daughters, sex workers like their mother, died of AIDS. The sole Jain in the book is a young nun about to starve herself to death after her best friend

contracted terminal TB. Kerala is represented by a Dalit Theyyam performer. Theyyam is undoubtedly one of the most spectacular of India's sacred rituals. It also acts as a unique social safety valve. But Dalrymple can't resist going over the top, accepting without question his interviewee's assertion that in the jail where he works, powerful inmates are always cutting off the noses and ears of people they don't like.

All this makes you wonder if Dalrymple is the most reliable guide to sacred South Asia. His strongest suit is his genuine love for the syncretic and folk religious traditions he describes.

He is proud to have had as his friend and colleague a performer of Rajasthan's Pabuji epic. He revels in the ecstatic drumming of the dargah of Shahbaz Lal Qalander in Sindh, and happily spends days in the company of the baul singers of Bengal. With them, perhaps, he comes closest to comprehending the sacred he is searching for. ■



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